



Historic feat: Vishal T.K. clocked 45.12s to win 400m, setting a new National Record.

Rising stars

Animesh Kujur (**below**) cemented his status as the Indian sprinter to watch, all but qualifying for the World Championships in the 200m. Kujur will be the first-ever Indian male sprinter to compete at the

highest level. The 22-year-old from Odisha skipped the 100m individual event in Chennai and focussed entirely on the 200m, where his chances of qualifying were strongest. In the final, he bettered his own meet record, clocking 20.63s.

In Kujur's absence, the men's 100m event produced a new star in Tamil Nadu's S. Tamarasu, who won in 10.22s, the joint fourth-fastest time ever by an Indian. His

performance also raised the question of whether he could have gone even faster had the organisers not scheduled the heats, semifinals, and final all on the same day.

The domestic meet had its biggest moment on the second day when local boy Vishal T.K. broke Kerala's Muhammed Anas' six-year-old National Record of 45.21s in the 400m with a time of 45.12s. A delighted Vishal removed his bib and displayed its other side, where he had written "For my coach Jason," referring to Jason Dawson, the Jamaican head coach of India's 4x400m men's national relay team.

While Dawson was extremely pleased with Vishal's performance, he also noted that he could produce more such results for the country if Indian coaches did not interfere in his programme. Later, addressing Dawson's complaint, Adille Sumariwalla, former president of the Athletics Federation of India, said, "This has been a topic of discussion for a long time. I don't want to get into the details, but there are issues, and we are resolving them."

